

"I am not a person who believes in a wish-list for the coming new year. Rather I am someone who believes in a work-list for myself"

"Regarding 2024, it is not a question of my confidence. The only thing in my hands is to give my everything in the service of the people. I am trying to do this with utmost honesty and commitment"

terminating a temporary provision. Despite Nehruji having said in Parliament that "*Ghiste ghiste ghis jayega* (it would erode and disappear one day)", for seven decades, the people of J&K were deprived of their rights, especially women and those from underprivileged communities. With Article 370 gone forever, the people of J&K and Ladakh, for the first time, are free to shape their destinies with their own hands. The Constitution of India, which protects the rights of socially vulnerable groups, is fully applicable to them. The women of J&K are today emerging in various fields, from sports to entrepreneurship. New industries are opening up. Terrorism has hit record lows while tourism is hitting record highs. International events, such as G20 meetings, have taken place, and the world has witnessed the hospitality and pristine beauty of the region.

Q. What are you doing to ensure sustained peace in Jammu & Kashmir?

The government has adopted a multi-pronged approach with focus on security, development, investment in infrastructure and human capital and a complete re-engineering of government processes through reforms. We are absolutely on the path of ensuring sustainable peace, stability and prosperity for the people of the region by improving their living standards, promoting economic growth and generating employment opportunities. J&K is already represented in our Parliament at the national level. At the local level, for the first time, we have been able to take democracy to the grassroots. A three-tier panchayati raj system has been established in the state and 35,000 leaders elected at the grassroots. Why do we underestimate the importance of these elections? Be it democracy, development or dynamism, today the people of J&K and Ladakh are seeing all-round progress in every aspect.

Q. The Modi government has given a major impetus to semiconductor chip manufacture and other critical and emerging technologies, apart from space exploration. What more do we need to do to make India self-reliant in these areas and become a technology superpower?

I am glad that you have noticed our efforts in these fields. It is unfortunate that for 30 years, people in power were merely running governments, not the nation. The semiconductor mission is something we should have started 30 years back. We are already late. They kept doubting the potential of our people and their abilities. Our people have tremendous abilities, be it in research or design. We have achieved great success in the field of atomic energy as well as space. The world is now seeing our dynamism in defence manufacturing through products like the BrahMos missile. I believe India has all the